

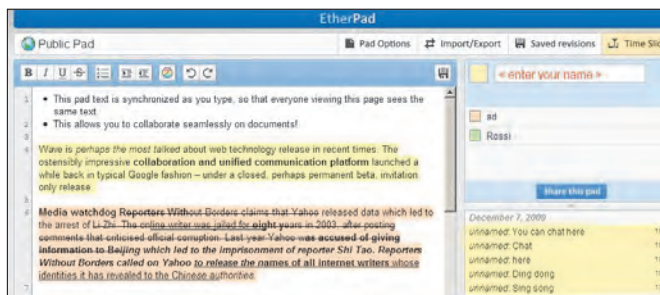


Surf's up!

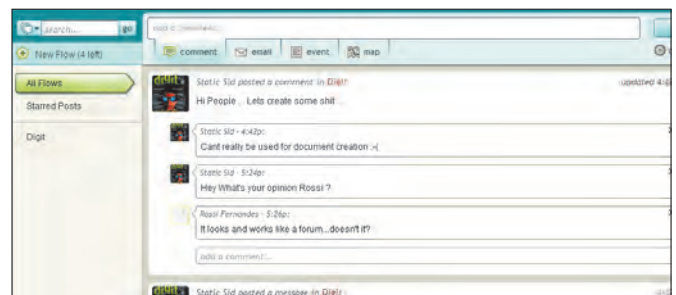
Don't know what to do with Wave? Read our coverage on Google Wave in the December 2009 Collector's Edition of Digit

HTC Touch HD2

HTC's popular Touch HD2 comes to India with a price tag of Rs. 30,000



EtherPad in action



Shareflow with near real time conversations

the Etherpad equivalent of the Timeline feature of Google Wave is absolutely smooth. It literally plays back the process of creating the document smoothly, almost like a movie. The process of getting in collaborators is also very simple – just mail or IM them a link. And the best part is that the interface is light and hence really fast. Also, work can begin instantly – no sign ups, registration or invites!

It's no surprise to us that Etherpad's official blog recently announced that they have been acquired by Google.

beWeeVee

"Why work alone?" is their motto, and it's quite true. This is a similar tool following a server hosted format for collaboration. Built on Silverlight, it is more basic than Etherpad, but definitely more stylised. It has done what Adobe's Buzzword did to a simple concept like Google Doc's word processor – putting a jazzy shell around a simple technology. It has standard functionality like saving revisions, but you can't export. Use this little tool if you want to start off quickly and the work you are collaborating on is not long and cumbersome.

Scribblar

Scribblar is yet another online collaboration tool which allows sharing images and video much like wave, but it's better classified as a white-boarding app. It strictly does not compare to the others featured here so far, because document creation is missing. Scribblar does feature a white-board and so in brainstorming use cases it comes of great use – more than Wave, in fact. The format followed by Scribblar is pretty simple. You can register or start off with a single click. The application creates a room for every team and that URL can be shared with others for calling other

collaborators to that room. With live chat, whiteboard, and file sharing, and no user limits, it makes for a fun web utility.

notepub

notepub is an online note taking app that allows for public collaboration. Its drag and drop features for adding images to a note comes the closest to Wave. You can start a note easily from the home page. Once you've created a note, you can share it by making it public and sending the link to those whom you want to collaborate with. If you were to create a note describing pictures from a recent holiday with friends, you can share it directly via twitter or Facebook. You can also link notes to other notes and hence there is a considerable amount of community play that comes into the picture. Still, this one is pretty low on usability and won't engage you as much as some of the others.

ShareFlow

This one is touted as perhaps the closest one can get to a Google Wave clone, and has been around for quite some time. ShareFlow debuted after Wave burst on to the scene last May at their developers' conference, so it's not quite clear who copied whom. Perhaps ShareFlow just beat Google to it by making their service available to the consumers sooner than Google – without those coveted invites. ShareFlow works beautifully as a replacement for sending group mails for decision making or sharing files. It has support for events, calendar events, and even a unique email address where you can send stuff that you want pinned to a particular flow. A focused environment is called a flow (like a Wave) and can be thought of as a folder containing all your files and conversations. It fails when it comes to document creation as unlike in Google Wave wherein at the end

of the wave when you collapse all comment bubbles, you're left with a usable document.

Synchroedit

"SynchroEdit is a browser-based simultaneous multi-user editor, a form of same-time, different-place group ware. It allows multiple users to edit a single web-based document at the same time, and it continuously synchronizes all changes so that users always have the same version.", says the web site. Sounds familiar? Well it is... And it's probably the oldest player in this game and hence retains that jaded web 1.0 look. But the interface itself looked quite good featuring rich text options. However, at the time of testing the server was down (and may even be permanently so, by the looks of the cob-web ridden home).

TextFlow

Based on Air, Text flow is perhaps the most aesthetically pleasing and yet powerful document collaboration tool out there. Apart from simple collaboration that can be achieved in near real time, it also offers version management of documents. It analyses multiple versions of a single document, conveniently highlighting changes in each version compared to the original, and allows you to chose and refuse through suggested changes to the document. Currently sign-ups are frozen on the textflow web site and it is invitation only.

Greener on the other site?

While all of these apps featured here serve you in most use cases, at times even better than Google Wave, they lack Wave's extension and gadget-ability. With that Wave can be put to use in virtually infinite scenarios. But do you really want everything? Or would you rather be focused on the need at hand? **d**